



Ethicare Resourcing

SOUTH ISLAND GUIDE · 2026

RELOCATION GUIDE

Central Otago

A relocation guide for healthcare professionals and their families. The work, the neighbourhoods, the money and the weekends in Central Otago.

Lakes, mountains, four seasons. And rural medicine with a view.

Deep glacial lakes, schist and thyme-covered hills, four true seasons and some of the most spectacular landscape in New Zealand. Plan your housing early and the rest falls into place; this guide shows you how people do it.

~65k

permanent residents
across the region

2

rural hospitals, linked to
Dunedin for complex
care

4

ski fields within about an
hour

~3 hrs

by road to Dunedin, the
referral centre

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Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Why people love Central Otago

It is the region people ask us about most. Understand how it works before you go, and Central Otago can be the best decision you ever make.

This guide covers two adjoining districts that function as one region: Queenstown Lakes, with Queenstown, Wānaka, Arrowtown and Hāwea, and Central Otago proper, the drier inland basins around Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde and the Maniototo. Together they hold around sixty-five thousand people, ringed by mountains.

Two things shape life here for a clinician. Care runs through rural hospitals and a strong community network, with complex cases going to Dunedin. And if lakeside living on a budget is the goal, Queenstown and Wānaka are not that. If you are drawn to orchards, sunshine and friendly towns, the inland basins could be a great choice, and many clinical families live there.



**People come for the landscape,
and stay for the life they build in it.**

What you get is remarkable. Four ski fields inside an hour. Lakes you swim in. Autumn that stops people in the street. Direct flights to Australia from a town of twenty-eight thousand. And a kind of clinical work, broad, autonomous and adventure-flavoured, that exists almost nowhere else.

Plenty of clinicians thrive here, and most have done one of three things. They live inland, where housing is far better value. They arrive as a two-income household. Or they come for a defined chapter of three to five years, with a clear plan.



The Southern Alps above farmland near Lake Wānaka.

WHAT YOU GAIN

Autonomy

Close-knit teams, broad skills in daily use, and decisions that are yours.

The outdoors as daily life

Skiing as a weekly habit, lakes in summer, and an autumn people travel the world for.

An easy place to make friends

Queenstown and Wānaka are wonderfully international, and so many people are new that friendships form quickly.

GOOD TO KNOW

Housing

Start your search early near the lakes, and look inland too, where there is more choice.

Career shape

If subspecialty training is your next step, Dunedin or Christchurch are the places for it. If you love broad rural practice, this is a rich chapter in any career.

A welcoming community

The lakes towns are full of newcomers, so friendships form fast; the inland towns offer longer roots.

Lakes in the west, basins in the east

Everywhere else in New Zealand has a maritime climate. Ringed by mountains that strip the weather of its rain, Central Otago is the one genuinely continental corner of the country.

The lakes sit in the west, where glaciers gouged deep troughs into the Southern Alps: Wakatipu with Queenstown on its edge, Wānaka and Hāwea to the north, the Remarkables and Mt Aspiring National Park behind. It is steep, dramatic country, wetter and greener.

East of the Kawarau Gorge the land opens into the basins: Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde and the Maniototo beyond. Rounded schist hills, thyme and wild rose, orchards and vineyards on the valley floors, and the Clutha River running through. Brown in summer, gold in autumn, crisp, frosty and often misty in winter.



Autumn around Lake Wānaka. You will get this from your kitchen window.

Summer

DEC – FEB

24–32°C. Hot, dry and brilliant, with fierce UV at altitude.

Sunburn can happen in twenty minutes, so sunscreen and a hat are everyday kit.

Autumn

MAR – MAY

14–22°C. The famous one: poplars and willows from lemon to rust against brown hills and blue water.

Winter

JUN – AUG

–2 to 10°C. Hard frosts, real snow, and inland fog that settles in the basins, often with sunshine on the tops above.

Spring

SEP – NOV

12–20°C. Blossom first, then breezy days.

**~350–
450mm**

annual rain in the
Alexandra basin

Semi-arid; Queenstown
gets roughly double

–10 to 35°C

the genuine annual range
inland

~28,000

people in Queenstown

Wānaka around ten
thousand

Homes here are built for the climate: insulation, double glazing and log burners are standard, so houses tend to be warmer than the national average. On winter inversion days, fog fills the inland basins while the tops sit in sunshine, and locals simply drive up into the light.

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Words you will hear

Central: the dry inland basins, as distinct from the lakes. Whakatipu: Lake Wakatipu, Whakatipu-wai-māori in full. The Crown: the Crown Range, the highest sealed road in the country. Frankton: Queenstown's flat, handy end, home to the hospital and airport. Shoulder: the calmer weeks between the ski and summer seasons.

Healthcare and work in Central Otago

The way care is organised here shapes which roles exist, so it is the first thing to understand. Everything else follows from it.

Care is delivered through a rural model run by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. A rural hospital at Frankton, on the edge of Queenstown, provides twenty-four-hour emergency care, inpatient beds, maternity and outpatient services for the Wakatipu basin. A second rural hospital serves the Cromwell, Clyde and Alexandra valley. Around them sits a strong primary and community network that is central to care.

What is referred out: intensive care, most surgical specialties, oncology, cardiology, neurology, and most hospital subspecialty work, principally to Dunedin, with Invercargill closer for some services and Christchurch used for others. Retrieval and transfer are a normal part of the working week.

○ The Wakatipu rural hospital

ON SITE

Emergency care, inpatient beds, maternity and outpatients, on the edge of Queenstown.

○ The valley rural hospital

~45 MIN

The region's second site, serving Cromwell, Clyde and Alexandra.

○ Invercargill

~2 HR 15

Closer than Dunedin for some services.

○ Dunedin

~3 HOURS

The main referral centre for intensive care, most surgical specialties, oncology, cardiology and neurology.

○ Christchurch

~6 HOURS

Used for some tertiary services. Some routes cross alpine passes, so check conditions in winter.

The caseload is distinctive. Sixty-five thousand residents and several million visitor nights a year, many spent skiing, biking, climbing and driving on unfamiliar roads, produce far more musculoskeletal and trauma presentation than the population would predict, peaking in the ski season. For emergency, orthopaedic, radiography, physiotherapy and pre-hospital clinicians, that is genuinely interesting work.

WHERE THE ROLES ARE

Strong fit

Rural generalist medicine, general practice, urgent care, emergency nursing, radiography, physiotherapy, community allied health, midwifery, paramedicine and retrieval.

CHECK BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Possible, with planning

Sonography, occupational therapy, mental health and addiction, aged care, and roles that combine a caseload with travel across the region.

A GREAT FIT FOR DUNEDIN OR CHRISTCHURCH

City-based specialties

Most hospital subspecialties, intensive care, radiation therapy, oncology, and anything requiring tertiary volume.

This is the rohe of Kāi Tahu, and health equity across a rural, dispersed and ageing population is a meaningful part of the work. Expect karakia at the start of meetings, te reo on the ward and whānau involved in decisions. Nobody expects you to arrive fluent; a genuine effort is warmly welcomed.

What to ask at interview

- ☐ Is there accommodation support? Ask this first, and ask it directly.
- ☐ What is referred out, where to, and what is my role in stabilising and transferring?
- ☐ How does the roster change between the winter peak and the shoulder season?
- ☐ What senior support is available on site and by phone, particularly overnight?
- ☐ What does the team's turnover look like, and how long do people typically stay?

Where to live: lakeside or inland

The lakeside and the inland towns are very different housing markets. Choosing between them is the biggest decision of the move, and it is one that opens doors.



A Queenstown residential street: lovely to live on, with prices to match.

WAKATIPU · THE HOSPITAL END

Frankton & Remarkables Park

The flat, convenient end of Queenstown: hospital, airport, supermarkets and most of the newer housing. Where many clinicians live.

WAKATIPU · WALK TO THE LAKE

Queenstown central & Fernhill

Beautiful and lively, with prices to match. Apartments and townhouses more than family homes.

WAKATIPU · FAMILY SUBDIVISIONS

Lake Hayes & Shotover Country

Modern warm houses and sensible commutes. The sweet spot for many families.

20 MIN FROM FRANKTON

Arrowtown

A gold-era village of stone cottages and autumn poplars. Genuine community, an excellent primary school, and prices that reflect it.

ITS OWN TOWN

Wānaka

Calmer and more residential, with good schooling. Prices sit close to Queenstown's and rentals go quickly, so start looking early.

10-20 MIN FROM WĀNAKA

Albert Town & Hāwea

More family-oriented and better value. A favourite with Wānaka families looking for more space for their money.

45 MIN FROM QUEENSTOWN

Cromwell

On Lake Dunstan among orchards and vineyards, with a college and everything a family needs. The most popular choice for clinical families.

INLAND CENTRAL

Alexandra & Clyde

Hot summers, crisp winters, and relaxed family living at everyday New Zealand prices. Charming Clyde costs a little more.



Arrowtown: a gold-era village with a real community.

Four things to sort before you commit

- ✓ Accommodation first. Ask your employer what support exists, start looking months ahead, and remember a short-term place makes a great first step.
- ✓ Secondary schooling. Each area has its own college, so the school you want may decide your town.
- ✓ Model the inland option properly. Cromwell or Alexandra with a forty-five-minute commute can leave you noticeably better off, often in a newer, warmer house.
- ✓ Winter access. If you will commute over the Crown Range, know your alternative route for July.



Lake Wānaka from the tracks above town.

Getting around by road and air

Two things surprise people: how much of life happens on scenic mountain roads, and that a resort town of twenty-eight thousand has direct international flights.

Driving is how the region connects. The towns are strung along valleys and lakesides, work may be in a different one from home, and the ski fields, trailheads and lakes all assume a vehicle. Most households run two, and a four-wheel drive or at least good winter tyres is a common first purchase.

Queenstown is lively for its size, and on the Frankton corridor twenty minutes can stretch to forty-five in peak season, so plan around it. The subsidised local bus network across the Wakatipu basin is cheap and well used, and a handy supplement to the car.

JOURNEY	TYPICAL TIME
Queenstown → Arrowtown	20 min
Queenstown → Coronet Peak / the Remarkables	25–40 min
Queenstown → Cromwell	45 min
Queenstown → Wānaka (Crown Range)	1 hr, weather permitting
Cromwell → Alexandra / Clyde	20–30 min
Queenstown → Dunedin	3 hr
Queenstown → Christchurch	6 hr, or 1 hr flying

Winter driving tips

- ✓ Check road conditions before leaving the house, and carry chains between June and September.
- ✓ Watch for black ice on shaded corners; it matters more than deep snow.
- ✓ The Crown Range is spectacular; the Cromwell route is the longer, safer alternative, and locals switch to it without fuss.
- ✓ If your commute crosses a pass, ask your employer about winter rostering.

Flying is one of the region's great advantages. Queenstown Airport sits at Frankton, minutes from the hospital, with frequent domestic flights and direct services to eastern Australia. For clinicians with family across the Tasman, it is easier than from most of New Zealand. Fog, snow and wind occasionally cause diversions, mostly in winter, so leave a buffer for anything important.



A quiet lakeside road in the South Island high country. Most journeys here look like this.

What it costs to live here

Housing is the part of a Central Otago move that rewards planning most. Near the lakes, finding a long-term rental matters as much as the price.

Three decades of international demand for a finite amount of buildable land in a glacial valley, plus a housing stock in which a large share is holiday homes, short-stay rental or seasonal-worker accommodation. Add a workforce that arrives every winter, and long-term rentals near the lakes are in high demand.

Clinical pay is national, so you earn the same here as anywhere else in New Zealand. That makes where you live the big lever: the inland towns stretch a salary much further, and employer accommodation support, where it is offered, makes a real difference. Start your housing search as early as your job search.



Hillside lodges above Queenstown. A large share of the housing here is holiday homes and short-stay rental.

~1.6×

rent in the Wakatipu basin
Against inland Central as
the baseline

~40%

less, living inland
Alexandra and Cromwell

10–20%

grocery premium
In Queenstown and
Wānaka, against a main
centre

AREA	WHERE IT SITS
Queenstown & central Wānaka	The top of the national range for rent and purchase
Frankton, Lake Hayes, Shotover Country	Where most of the family-friendly housing is, at lakeside prices
Arrowtown & Kelvin Heights	Village charm and lakeside views, priced accordingly
Albert Town & Hāwea	Meaningfully cheaper than Wānaka itself
Cromwell	A different market: family homes at a fraction of lakeside prices
Alexandra, Clyde & the Maniototo	The most affordable housing in the region by a wide margin

HOLIDAY-TOWN PRICES

Eating out

Restaurants are priced for visitors, so locals tend to cook at home more and save eating out for a treat.

WORTH BUDGETING

Winter power and a winter car

Heating, plus tyres, chains and servicing. Both are worth spending properly on.

PLAN FOR IT

The mountain habit

Season passes, gear, bikes, boats. It is a big part of why you came, so give it a line in the budget.



You can live well here on a clinical salary. Most people start by renting, and many find their long-term home inland.



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

What I tell people about Central Otago

Everyone asks me about Queenstown, and I love that they do. My first questions back are about housing and about their profession, because the region runs on rural hospitals and community care, and the right role makes everything else fall into place.

A holiday here and a life here are different things, so I help people picture the everyday: the school run with the lake beside it, a Saturday at Cardrona, cherries from a roadside stall. Many of the happiest families I know here live inland, in Cromwell or Alexandra, and wouldn't swap.

When it lines up, I have never seen anyone regret it. The people who thrive love broad, hands-on work and want the landscape to be part of every single day.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



Summer evenings outdoors: the everyday life I help people picture.



Christmas with friends: newcomer communities across New Zealand look out for one another.

Fruit, wine and everyday life

Hot days, cold nights and irrigation turn out to be very good at stone fruit and pinot noir. Both are as good as anywhere, and both are grown within half an hour of each other.

Cherries and apricots arrive from Cromwell and Roxburgh in December and January, sold from roadside stalls and orchard gates. Then peaches, nectarines, plums, berries and apples through to autumn. Central Otago is also the southernmost wine region in the world, and Saturday lunch at a cellar door in Bannockburn or Gibbston becomes ordinary rather than an occasion.

Queenstown has a restaurant scene far beyond its size, excellent at the top end and priced for people on holiday. Wānaka is more relaxed and better value. Arrowtown and Clyde each have some lovely places to eat.



Queenstown's lakefront, lively all year round with locals and visitors alike.

THE RHYTHM OF THE YEAR

Two peaks, two lulls

Ski winter and high summer are full and fast. April–May and October–November are calmer, better value and, most locals say, the best of it.

EASY TO JOIN

A welcoming, mobile community

Seasonal workers come and go, so the lakes towns are easy to join. Inland communities take a little longer to get to know, then become friends for life.

JOIN A CLUB

Everything is outdoors

Cycling, tramping, ski, netball, rugby. A club is the fastest route to knowing people properly.

DUNEDIN OR CHRISTCHURCH

Big events, a drive away

There is a lively local events calendar. For major touring acts, galleries and theatre, Dunedin and Christchurch make good weekends away.

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Worth planning for

The big supermarkets are at Frankton, Wānaka, Cromwell and Alexandra. If you rely on specialist or imported ingredients, a quick check before you come is worthwhile, and Dunedin makes a good stock-up trip. Online deliveries to inland addresses can take a little longer.



Market stalls and roadside stands: in season, the region eats what it grows.

Snow, lakes and the rail trail

This part speaks for itself. Whatever you love outdoors, the region delivers it in abundance.



Four ski fields within about an hour. A weekly habit, not an annual holiday.



Queenstown at dusk, with the Remarkables catching the last light.



Jet boats on the Shotover. The rivers are a weekend in themselves.

Coronet Peak is twenty-five minutes from Queenstown, with night skiing: the one you go to after a day shift. The Remarkables has wide bowls and good learning terrain. Cardrona, on the Crown Range, is the family favourite. Treble Cone, Wānaka's field, is the one for steep, advanced terrain. A season here needs no flights and no accommodation, which changes what skiing costs and what it is.

In summer, Wakatipu, Wānaka and Hāwea are deep, cold, clear lakes that are genuinely swimmable in January. Lake Dunstan at Cromwell is warmer and shallower, where inland families spend their summers on the water. Then the rivers, the Kawarau, Shotover, Clutha and Matukituki, for jet boats, rafting and fishing.

CLYDE TO MIDDLEMARCH

Otago Central Rail Trail

New Zealand's first Great Ride, on an old railway formation. Gentle, peaceful, and one of the great multi-day rides anywhere.

CROMWELL TO CLYDE

Lake Dunstan Trail

Spectacular enough to be worth moving here for on its own.

WĀNAKA

Roys Peak & Isthmus Peak

Steep, challenging and worth every step. Go early to have them to yourself.

FROM WĀNAKA & GLENORCHY

Mt Aspiring National Park

Rob Roy Glacier for a day, the Routeburn and Rees-Dart for longer.

SUMMER

Lake days

Swimming, paddleboards and picnics at lake beaches in Wānaka, Frankton and on Lake Dunstan, where inland families spend summer.

WEEKENDS

Markets and orchards

Craft and farmers' markets around the region, and cherries and apricots from orchard gates in December and January.

GIBBSTON & BANNOCKBURN

Cellar doors

A long Saturday lunch among the vines is an ordinary weekend here, not a special occasion.

ALL SEASONS

Bikes for everyone

Flat lakeside trails for children, the rail trail for a family adventure, and world-class mountain biking for the keen.

SATURDAY MORNINGS

Club sport

Netball, rugby, football and ski and snowboard clubs. The fastest way for children and parents to make friends.

THROUGH THE YEAR

Festivals

The Queenstown Winter Festival, the Arrowtown Autumn Festival and the Alexandra Blossom Festival each mark the turn of a season.

Day trips and weekends further afield

Central Otago sits in the middle of the South Island's most famous country. Fiordland, the Mackenzie Basin, the West Coast and the southern coast are all within an easy long weekend.

Within the region itself there is enough for years of weekends: Glenorchy and the head of Lake Wakatipu, the Matukituki Valley into Mt Aspiring National Park, the gold-era village of St Bathans, and the wide, quiet Maniototo. Two hours south-west, Te Anau is the gateway to Fiordland and Milford Sound.

The coast is an easy drive too. Dunedin, the nearest city, has surf beaches, a university, museums and the Otago Peninsula's albatross and penguins, about three hours from Queenstown and less from Alexandra. Beyond it lies the Catlins coast, and to the north the turquoise lakes of the Mackenzie Basin.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Lake beaches	In town	Swimming in summer at Wānaka, Frankton and Lake Dunstan in Cromwell
Coronet Peak & the Remarkables	25–40 min from Queenstown	Two ski fields on Queenstown's doorstep, with night skiing at Coronet Peak
Cardrona & Treble Cone	~30–40 min from Wānaka	Cardrona for families and learners, Treble Cone for the steep stuff
Queenstown Airport	Frankton	Domestic flights, and direct services to eastern Australia
Glenorchy	~45 min from Queenstown	The head of the lake, and the start of the Routeburn
Otago Central Rail Trail	From Clyde	Gentle multi-day cycling through old railway country
Te Anau & Milford Sound	~2 hrs / ~4 hrs	Fiordland: lakes, glow-worm caves and the most famous fiord in the country
Dunedin, the nearest city	~3 hrs from Queenstown	University city with St Clair surf beach, museums and wildlife
Nearest surf beach	~2 hrs from Alexandra	St Clair and St Kilda in Dunedin; the Catlins coast is ~3 hrs

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Lake Tekapo & Mackenzie Basin	~2 hrs 30 from Wānaka	Turquoise lakes, stargazing and Aoraki / Mount Cook
Christchurch	~6 hrs, or ~1 hr flight	The South Island's largest city and main airport

~45 MIN

Glenorchy

A lakeside drive to a village ringed by mountains, with walks, horse treks and the start of famous tracks.

~1 HR FROM WĀNAKA

Mt Aspiring National Park

The Matukituki Valley and the Rob Roy Glacier track: a big day out that older children can manage.

~1 HR FROM ALEXANDRA

St Bathans & the Maniototo

An old gold-mining village beside the Blue Lake, and huge, quiet skies.

~2-4 HRS

Fiordland & Milford Sound

Te Anau for the lake and glow-worm caves, then the road to Milford Sound for a cruise beneath sheer walls.

~2-3 HRS

Dunedin & the Otago Peninsula

A university city with beaches, galleries and good shops, and albatross and penguins on the peninsula.

~3 HRS

The Catlins

Empty golden bays, waterfalls in native bush, and sea lions on the sand.

~3 HRS FROM WĀNAKA

Haast Pass & the West Coast

Waterfalls and rainforest over the pass, then wild beaches and the glaciers to the north.



Autumn willows on the shore of Lake Wānaka.



Fiordland, a long day trip west via Te Anau.



The Catlins coast, about three hours south-east:
the region's nearest wild beaches.

Schools and family life

Skiing, lakes, mountains, space and safety. Families do very well here, especially those who choose their town with schools in mind.



Skiing, lakes, mountains and space: the outdoor childhood families come for.

Children here grow up outside. Lake beaches in summer, learn-to-ski programmes at Cardrona and the Remarkables in winter, bike trails from the back door and an autumn spent kicking leaves. The towns are small, safe and friendly, and most children walk or bike to school.

Pools, libraries, playgrounds and clubs are spread across the towns, with the larger recreation centres in Frankton and Wānaka. Kids' sport, ski clubs and school holiday programmes are busy, and they are where many parents make their first friends.

What children tend to love here

- ✓ Ski school from a young age, with learner areas at Cardrona, the Remarkables and Coronet Peak.
- ✓ Lake swimming and paddleboarding at Wānaka, Frankton and Lake Dunstan.
- ✓ The Queenstown Gardens, with playgrounds, frisbee golf and lake views.
- ✓ Puzzling World in Wānaka, and the luge on the hill above Queenstown.
- ✓ Cherry picking in Cromwell in early summer.

Schooling follows the national pattern. State schools are free at primary and secondary level, though most ask for a voluntary donation; state-integrated schools, often Catholic, add a special character for attendance dues; and independent schools are mostly found in the cities. Children usually start school at five, and school is compulsory from six to sixteen.

Each part of the region has its own secondary school: Wakatipu High School in Queenstown, Mount Aspiring College in Wānaka, Cromwell College and Dunstan High School in Alexandra. Primary schools sit in almost every town, with Arrowtown's especially well regarded.

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School zones and reports

Some of the region's schools run enrolment schemes (zones), so check the zone before you sign a lease. With one secondary school per area, the college you want may well decide your town. You can read any school's Education Review Office report at ero.govt.nz.

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Early childhood and further study

The government funds up to 20 hours a week of early childhood education for three to five-year-olds. Childcare places are in demand in the lakes towns, so put your name down as soon as you have a start date. Otago Polytechnic has a campus in Cromwell, and the University of Otago is in Dunedin.



Time on the water is an ordinary weekend here, not a holiday.



Bush walks are free, close and good for every age.

FOR FAMILIES, IN SHORT

- ✓ Pick your school, then your town.
- ✓ Lake Hayes, Shotover Country, Hāwea and Cromwell are where families tend to find space and newer, warmer houses.
- ✓ Some specialist children's services are in Dunedin, so plan for the occasional trip.
- ✓ Join a club in the first month. It is how children and parents both find their people.

“

Plan the life, not just the view, and Central Otago gives back more than you expect.

Your Central Otago address book

The Queenstown Lakes district has an unusually international workforce and a growing set of migrant groups (Indian, Filipino, Sri Lankan, Nepalese, Fijian and more) that the council lists in one place. Inland Cromwell and Alexandra have less, so families there usually connect through the Queenstown groups.

COUNCILS

Queenstown Lakes District Council

Queenstown, Wānaka and Arrowtown: rubbish, rates, libraries and consents

qldc.govt.nz

Central Otago District Council

Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde and the inland towns

codc.govt.nz

Otago Regional Council

The regional council, and the Orbus bus network in Queenstown

orc.govt.nz

REGIONAL TOURISM AND WHAT'S ON

Destination Queenstown

Official guide to Queenstown, events and seasons

queenstownnz.co.nz

Lake Wānaka Tourism

Official guide to Wānaka and the Upper Clutha

lakewanaka.co.nz

Tourism Central Otago

Trails, wineries and the inland towns

centralotagonz.com

COMMUNITY & CULTURAL ASSOCIATIONS

QLDC Welcoming Communities

The council's newcomer programme: Welcoming Week, newcomer events and support for migrant groups.

qldc.govt.nz/community/welcoming-communities

Pacific & migrant community groups (QLDC)

One-page profiles of about 15 local ethnic groups, with how to contact each.

qldc.govt.nz/community/welcoming-communities/pacific-and-migrant-community-groups

QLDC Newcomers Guide

Downloadable guide to living in the district: schools, health, work, housing, transport and costs.

qldc.govt.nz/community/newcomers-guide

Queenstown Fijian Community Charitable Trust

Fiji Day and Fijian Language Week, and support for newly arrived Fijian families.

queenstownfijiancommunitycharitabletrust.com

Other migrant groups

QLDC's profile list also covers Nepalese, Korean, Japanese, Malaysian, Indonesian, Taiwanese and Latin American groups.

qldc.govt.nz/community/welcoming-communities/pacific-and-migrant-community-groups

Happiness House

Wakatipu community centre: support and advocacy, referrals, a play area, and affordable second-hand clothes and school uniforms.

happinesshouse.org.nz

English Language Partners (Queenstown classes)

Free English classes in Queenstown, run from the Dunedin centre.

03 455 5266 englishlanguage.org.nz/dunedin

New Zealand Newcomers Network

Coffee mornings and social events for people new to the area; find the Central Otago or Queenstown group on the site.

newcomers.co.nz

Citizens Advice Bureau

Free, confidential help with anything from tenancy to tax, with interpreters available.

0800 367 222 cab.org.nz

FACEBOOK & ONLINE GROUPS

Queenstown Indian Community

About 1,500 members across Queenstown, Wānaka and Cromwell: festivals, guidance for newcomers and community notices.

facebook.com/queenstownindiancommunity

Bhartiya Samaj Queenstown

Indian cultural charity: Lohri, Holi, Teej, Independence Day and a Diwali night of up to 2,000 people.

facebook.com/info.bsq

Queenstown Association of Migrant Pinoys (QAMPI)

Filipino group since 2008: Independence Day, Sinulog, Christmas party, regular mass, sports and courses.

facebook.com/groups/qampi

Sri Lankan Association Queenstown

Sri Lankan families in Queenstown, Wānaka and Alexandra: New Year, Wesak, Independence Day and cricket.

facebook.com/groups/1319481091530070

Guru Nanak Darbar Queenstown

Gurdwara news, festival dates and langar times.

facebook.com/gurunanakdarbarqueenstown

PLACES OF WORSHIP

St Joseph's Catholic Church, Queenstown

Catholic parish church in central Queenstown.

Catholic parishes in Wānaka, Cromwell and Alexandra

Holy Family (Wānaka), Irish Martyrs (Cromwell) and St John the Baptist (Alexandra).

Malayalam services

None locally. The Christchurch Syro-Malabar mission and the Mar Thoma parish (which covers Otago) are the nearest.

syromalabarchristchurch.org.nz

St Peter's Anglican Church, Queenstown

Anglican parish church in central Queenstown.

St Andrew's Presbyterian Church, Queenstown

Presbyterian parish in Queenstown.

Guru Nanak Darbar Queenstown

Gurdwara (temporary building) at Hanley's Farm: services, festivals, langar and Punjabi classes for 600 to 700 Sikhs across the district.

facebook.com/gurunanakdarbarqueenstown

MyFundAction centre, Frankton

Daily and Friday Islamic prayers, talks and Ramadan events at 1/13 Red Oaks Drive, Frankton.

03 657 1010 instagram.com/myfundaction.anz

Southern Lakes Jewish Community

Progressive, culture-focused community from Glenorchy to Wānaka and Cromwell, marking the main festivals together; contact via the QLDC group profiles page.

qldc.govt.nz/community/welcoming-communities/pacific-and-migrant-community-groups

HALAL, KOSHER & INTERNATIONAL GROCERIES

Specialist groceries

The range here is narrow. Most families stock up on trips to Dunedin or Christchurch, or order online.

ISM Mart (Dunedin) online shop

Dunedin Indian grocer with an online shop: spices, rice, lentils, pickles and Kerala brands.

03 455 2011 ismdn.co.nz

Yogiji's Food Mart (Christchurch)

Large Indian supermarket worth a stop when you are in Christchurch.

yogijis.co.nz

Halal food

Ask the MyFundAction community in Frankton about current halal meat sources; many supermarket lines are halal-certified.

Kosher food

Nothing local; the Southern Lakes Jewish Community is the contact for sourcing.

SUPERMARKETS & MARKETS

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains, warehouse-style. Check the store finder for the nearest one to your town.

paknsave.co.nz/store-finder

Woolworths

Mid-range chain with the best online ordering and delivery. Check the site for the nearest store and delivery area.

woolworths.co.nz

New World

Slightly pricier, with a better fresh and speciality range. Check the site for the nearest store.

newworld.co.nz

Where locals shop

The big supermarkets are at Frankton, Wānaka, Cromwell and Alexandra; lakeside prices carry a resort premium.

Farmers' markets

Cromwell and Alexandra farmers' markets for produce; Queenstown and Wānaka markets for food and craft. Days change with the season.

Orchard stalls

Cherries and apricots from roadside stalls and orchard gates around Cromwell and Roxburgh in December and January.

SCHOOLS, UNIFORMS & FAMILIES

Education Counts school finder

Find schools near an address and check which school zone a house falls in.

educationcounts.govt.nz/find-school

NZ Uniforms

Uniform stockist with a Queenstown store; also check each school's own uniform shop and PTA sales.

nzuniforms.com

Happiness House second-hand uniforms

Affordable second-hand school uniforms and children's clothes in the Wakatipu.

happinesshouse.org.nz

Plunket

Free health and development checks for under-fives, parent groups and PlunketLine advice (0800 933 922).

0800 933 922 plunket.org.nz

Playcentre

Parent-led early childhood centres and playgroups, good for meeting other families.

playcentre.org.nz

Queenstown Lakes Libraries

Libraries in Queenstown, Frankton, Arrowtown and Wānaka, with school holiday programmes.

qldclibraries.govt.nz

Central Otago libraries

District libraries in Cromwell, Alexandra and the smaller towns.

codc.govt.nz/services/libraries

HOUSING & AREAS

Trade Me Property: Queenstown-Lakes rentals

The main rental listings site. Stock is thin, so set up alerts before you arrive.

trademe.co.nz/a/property/residential/rent/otago/queenstown-lakes

Trade Me Property: Central Otago rentals

Rentals in Cromwell, Alexandra, Clyde and inland towns.

trademe.co.nz/a/property/residential/rent/otago/central-otago

realestate.co.nz: Central Otago / Lakes rentals

Second listings site for the region.

realestate.co.nz/residential/rental/otago/central-otago

Tenancy Services market rent tool

Look up what similar homes actually rent for, by suburb and bedrooms.

tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent

QLDC property information search

Rates and property information for Queenstown, Wānaka and Arrowtown addresses.

qldc.govt.nz/services/rates-property/property-information-search

CODC rating and property search

Rates and property information for Cromwell, Alexandra and Clyde addresses.

codc.govt.nz/do-it-online/rating-and-property-search

GETTING AROUND

Orbus Queenstown (Otago Regional Council)

Wakatipu buses to Frankton, Arrowtown, Kelvin Heights and Jack's Point, plus the lake ferry.

0800 672 8778

orc.govt.nz/orbus/queenstown-bus-ferry-timetables

Bee Card

The bus fare card for Queenstown and Otago, cheaper than cash; Motu Move is due to replace it.

beecard.co.nz

Queenstown Airport

At Frankton, with domestic flights and direct services to Australia.

queenstownairport.co.nz

InterCity

Long-distance coaches linking South Island towns and cities.

intercity.co.nz

NZ Transport Agency (NZTA)

Converting an overseas licence, road rules and live road conditions.

nzta.govt.nz

AA

Licence tests and conversions, vehicle checks and roadside membership at AA centres.

aa.co.nz

COST OF LIVING COMPARISONS

Numbeo: Queenstown

Crowd-sourced prices to compare with your home city.

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Queenstown

Powerswitch

Compare power and broadband plans for your address.

powerswitch.org.nz

Sorted

Free budgeting and money tools from the Retirement Commission.

sorted.org.nz

Stats NZ

Official prices, incomes and census data by area.

stats.govt.nz



Checked October 2026

Community groups, shops and pages change. If a link has moved or you know a group we should add, tell us and we will update the guide.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The national services every newcomer uses, wherever in New Zealand you land.

EMERGENCIES & HEALTH ADVICE

Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time

111

Healthline

Free 24/7 health advice from a nurse, in any language

0800 611 116

Need to talk?

Free call or text a trained counsellor, 24/7

1737

National Poisons Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned

0800 764 766

PlunketLine

Free 24/7 support for parents of under-fives

0800 933 922

VISAS, REGISTRATION & WORK

Immigration New Zealand

Visas, the Green List and residence pathways

immigration.govt.nz

Immigration Advisers Authority

Check an adviser is licensed before you pay

iaa.govt.nz

Responsible authorities

The registration board for every regulated health profession

health.govt.nz/regulated-health-professions

Nursing Council of New Zealand

Registration for nurses

nursingcouncil.org.nz

Medical Council of New Zealand

Registration for doctors

mcnz.org.nz

HEALTHCARE FOR YOUR FAMILY

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora

How public healthcare works and who is eligible

tewhatuora.govt.nz

Healthpoint

Find a GP, pharmacy, dentist or urgent care near you

healthpoint.co.nz

ACC

Accident cover for everyone in New Zealand, including visitors

acc.co.nz

SCHOOLS & CHILDCARE

Find a school

Every school, with its enrolment zone

educationcounts.govt.nz/find-school

Education Review Office

Independent reports on schools and early learning

ero.govt.nz

Parents and whānau

How schooling, early childhood education and fees work

parents.education.govt.nz

MONEY, HOME & GETTING AROUND

Inland Revenue (IRD)

Your IRD number, tax and KiwiSaver
ird.govt.nz

Tenancy Services

Renting rules, bonds and market rents by area
tenancy.govt.nz

NZ Transport Agency

Converting your overseas driver licence
nzta.govt.nz/driver-licences

Powerswitch

Compare power companies in your area
powerswitch.org.nz

Sorted

Free, independent budgeting tools
sorted.org.nz

MPI · pets

Bringing cats and dogs into New Zealand
mpi.govt.nz/bring-send-to-nz/pets-travelling-to-nz

SETTLING IN

Citizens Advice Bureau

Free, confidential help with almost any question
0800 367 222 cab.org.nz

Ministry for Ethnic Communities

Support and connections for new migrant communities
ethniccommunities.govt.nz

Department of Conservation

Huts, tracks, campsites and Great Walks bookings
doc.govt.nz



Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not licensed immigration advisers.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

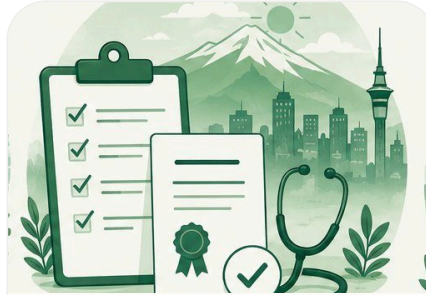
Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to New Zealand registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

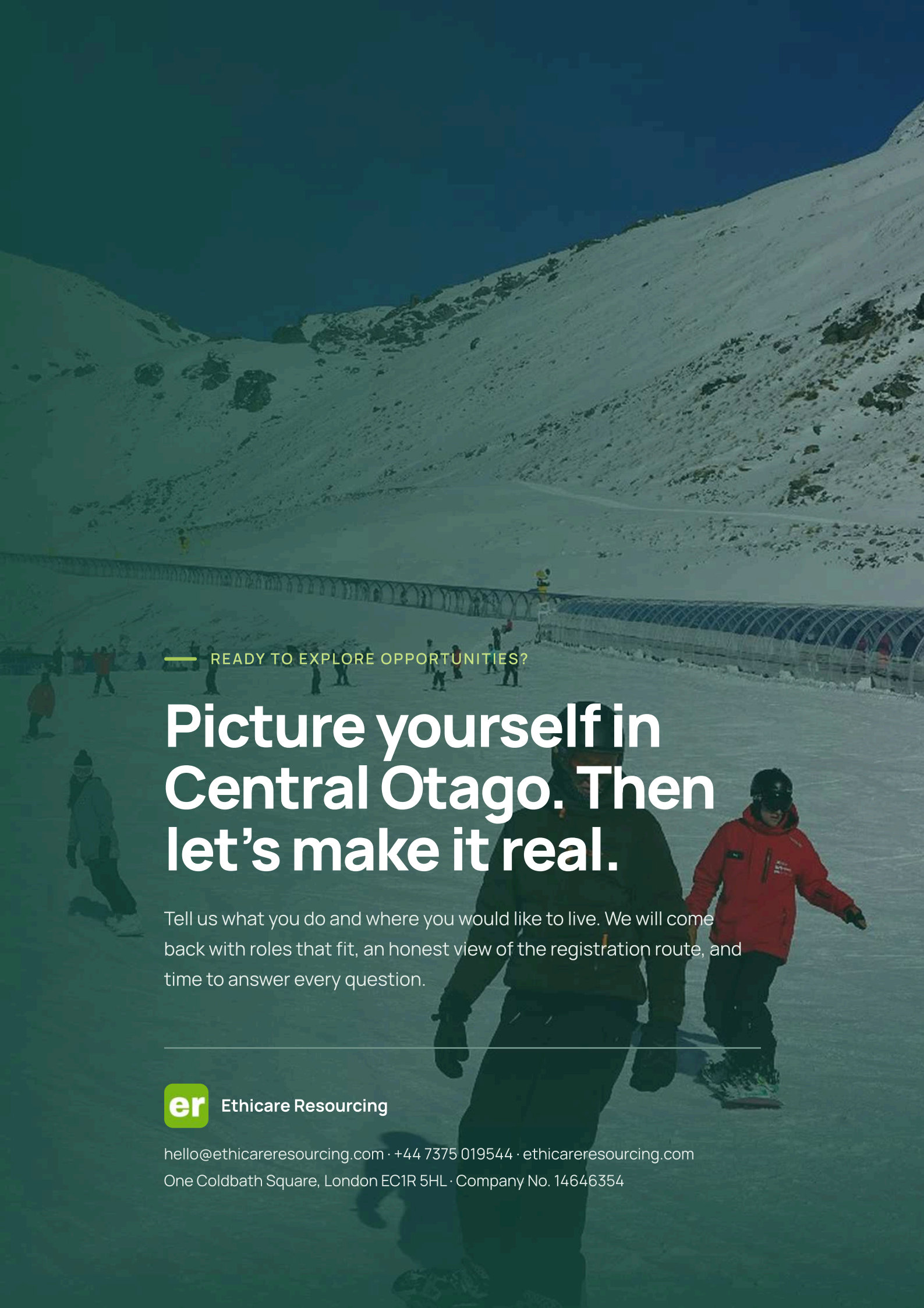
Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.



— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Central Otago. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, an honest view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



Ethicare Resourcing

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